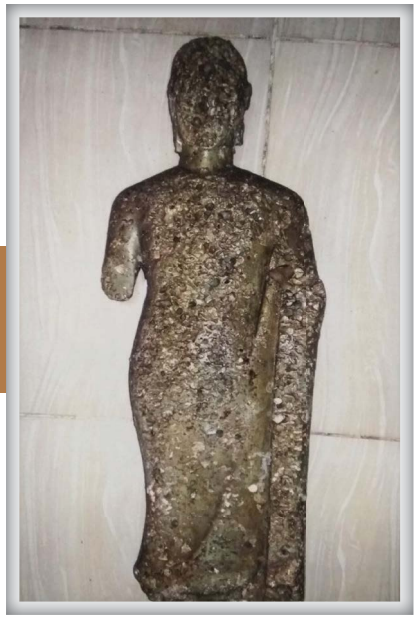




Kaveripoompattinam/ Poompuhar

The coastal town of Kaveripoompattinam (now known as Poompuhar) was an important Buddhist centre in ancient times. Excavations here have unearthed numerous relics, including Buddhist sculptures, stupas, and votive tablets. These artifacts provide valuable insights into the maritime connections between Tamil Nadu and Southeast Asia.When a tsunami hit the Tamil Nadu coast in 2004, evidences of an ancient city beneath the ocean's depths emerged. Subsequently, marine archaeologists unearthed submerged structures, along with an intact Buddha statue, revealing the secrets of this submerged metropolis.Excavations carried out at Pallavanesvaram, about a kilometre inland, have revealed the remains of an ancient Buddhist vihara and chaitya.The remains of another Buddhist monastery have been discovered at Manigramam nearby.

Thiyaganur Buddhas

The Thiyaganur Buddha statues are a significant collection of historical Buddhist artifacts located in Thiyaganur, a village in Tamil Nadu's Salem district.There are two magnificent Buddha images measuring approximately 6 feet in height, both depicted in a seated posture. One of these images is enshrined within a small temple.Remarkably, this temple is the sole surviving Buddhist temple in all of Tamil Nadu. In 2013, a meditation hall was constructed with the support of public contributions to accommodate one of the Buddha images situated on a private farm. Historians attribute the creation of these images to the 11th century.The presence of the Buddhas shows that Thiyaganur wasone of the renowned Buddhist centres of yore.

Nagapattinam

The small coastal town of Nagapattinam is renowned for its Buddhist heritage. The once thriving port was a prominent centre for Buddhist learning. A Buddhist temple was built at Nagapattinam especially for Chinese Buddhists during the reign of the Pallava ruler Narasimhavarman II (c. AD 695–722).The Chinese monk Wu-hing visited the site while going to Sri Lanka.The Sumatran king Sri Maravijayattungavarmanhad the Chudamani Vihara built here in 1006 CE with the support of Rajaraja Chola I.Since 1856, about 350 bronze statues of Buddha have been found at Nagapattinam, dating from the 11th to the 16th century CE. In Nagapattinam district, the coastal village of Pushpavanam (which literally means 'Garden of Flowers') is home to an impressive seated Buddha. The statue currently sits under a Bodhi tree and is looked after by the locals.



Other Buddhist Sites

Apart from the major sites, many smaller Buddhist sites can be seen across Tamil Nadu. In 2004, numerous Buddhist artifacts were discovered in Sellur village of Thiruvarur district. At Thirunellikaval in the same district, an ancient Buddha statue can be seen.Tiruchirappalli too is home to several impressive Buddha statues. An ancient Buddhist stupa found in Putheri, is possibly the southernmost stupa discovered in India so far, lying just 20 kilometres from Cape Comorin.

With this overview of the traces of Buddhism in Tamil Nadu, we can see the profound impact it had on the cultural tapestry of the region. The serene sites which can still be seen not only provide a tranquil escape but also serve as windows into the ancient past, enlightening us about the deep connections between diverse cultures and spiritual traditions.